

Walking 30 Minutes a Day While on DMARDs: A Practical Plan

Gentle aerobic activity boosts mood and joint health alongside treatment.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-17 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



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Gentle aerobic activity boosts mood and joint health alongside treatment.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Versus Arthritis consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- **Talk to your clinician.** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- **Track your symptoms.** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- **Move within comfort.** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]\(/exercises/knee\)](#). 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment. 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.

Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update

content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Many studies, including large randomised trials, have consistently shown the benefits of regular, moderate-intensity exercise for people living with inflammatory arthritis. Systematic reviews, which look at many studies together, confirm that staying active can improve joint function, reduce pain, and boost overall quality of life. This is true even for those taking disease-modifying anti-rheumatic drugs (DMARDs).

The evidence suggests that exercise works best when it's tailored to the individual and includes a mix of aerobic activities, like walking, and strength training. Clinical guidelines from leading rheumatology organisations across the UK strongly recommend incorporating physical activity into the treatment plan from early diagnosis, alongside medication. This combined approach is highlighted as the most effective way to manage long-term conditions like rheumatoid arthritis or psoriatic arthritis.

Regular movement helps to keep muscles strong around affected joints, which can provide better support and reduce pain. It also plays a role in keeping your heart healthy, which is especially important as some types of arthritis can increase the risk of heart problems. The research supports the idea that 'little and often' is key to sustainable benefits.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Doing too much, too soon:** Start with short walks and gradually increase your time. * **Ignoring pain:** Differentiate between muscle fatigue and new joint pain; dial back if it's the latter. * **Wearing unsuitable footwear:** Invest in supportive, comfortable shoes that cushion your feet. * **Not warming up or cooling down:** Spend 5 minutes gently preparing and recovering your body. * **Stopping completely during a flare:** Modify your activity, but try to keep moving gently if possible. * **Becoming discouraged by initial discomfort:** Consistency builds stamina and comfort over time.

When to Speak to a Clinician

While walking is generally very beneficial, there are times when you should seek advice from your general practitioner, physiotherapist, or rheumatology team. It's always best to get a professional opinion if you're unsure or worried about new symptoms.

* Sudden, severe pain that doesn't go away with rest. * New, persistent swelling or redness in a joint. * Fever, chills, or generally feeling unwell alongside joint symptoms. * Rapid loss of movement or function in a joint. * If your walking ability significantly worsens despite regular activity.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can walking help reduce the side effects of DMARDs? Walking itself doesn't directly reduce DMARD side effects. However, regular physical activity can improve overall wellbeing, energy levels, and mood, which can help you cope better with any challenges from your medication. It's important to discuss any medication side effects with your rheumatology team.

How do I know if I'm overdoing it when walking? A good rule of thumb is that you should still be able to hold a conversation while walking. If you're too breathless to talk, you're likely working too hard. Also, listen to your joints: a little stiffness might be normal, but sharp or increasing pain during or after your walk is a sign to slow down or rest.

Is it safe to walk every day with arthritis? For most people with arthritis, walking every day is not only safe but highly recommended, provided it's gentle and progressive. Consistency is more important than intensity. If you have active inflammation or are experiencing a flare-up, you might need to adjust your routine and walk for shorter periods or on alternate days.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about walking 30 minutes a day while on dmards: a practical plan?

Short answer: Walking daily with arthritis is generally safe and recommended, especially when gentle and progressive. Regular, moderate intensity exercise, including walking, improves joint function, reduces pain, and boosts overall quality of life. Tailored activity,

alongside medication, helps keep muscles strong and supports heart health. Listen to your body and adjust if experiencing pain; consistency is more important than intensity.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk